Introduction

On a hot, steamy day on the campaign trail in Varanasi, I was given another reminder of the enduring attraction of an Indian election. Stopping for a cool drink at the city's famous Pehelwan Lassi shop, we asked the owner whom he was going to vote for. Twirling his luxuriant moustache, Pehelwan Chacha looked at us. *'Jo Baba Jagannath aur dil kahe!'* (Whatever God and my heart tell me.) I tried to press him further—Narendra Modi or Arvind Kejriwal? As he lovingly laced the lassi with sinful dollops of *rabri*, he shot back, *'Dekhiye, sir, vote hamara hai, aap ko kyon batayein?'* (The vote is mine, why should I tell you?)

For more than five decades now, millions of Indians like Pehelwan Chacha have lined up across the country to exercise their franchise with hope and resolve. It is the one day when the gap between the *khaas aadmi* and the *aam aadmi*, between the *lal-batti* car and the auto rickshaw, between a Forbes billionaire and a BPL family, dissolves. We all stand in line waiting to have our fingers inked. If someone tries to break the queue —as actor-MP Chiranjeevi tried to in Hyderabad this time—you can find your voice and ask them to get back in line.

It is a truism that the higher income groups in India tend to vote less than the poor—the quest for equality is a constant motivator for the have-nots. Georgina from north Bengal, mainstay of our household for two decades, had never voted in her life and didn't have a voter card for the Delhi assembly elections. When we finally managed to get her one before the 2014 elections she was overjoyed. On voting day, she just couldn't stop smiling, showing her finger to anyone who would care to see. Her twinkling eyes reflected a sense of feeling genuinely empowered. *'Sir, hamne bhi vote daala'* (I voted too), she reported to me triumphantly.